

Episode 34: Once Upon a Time... (25) *Saint Seiya* Part 12 – And After 15 Years, "*Saint Seiya Hades Twelve Temples Arc*" Begins

Did you watch *The File of Young Kindaichi SP* that aired over two weeks? Behind that main broadcast, I attended the Anime Style *Mononoke* event.

I'd only watched *Mononoke* on TV, but Director Nakamura-kun (中村) is somewhat of a friend, several main staff are also *Hakaba* staff, and above all I heard Colour Designer Nagai-san (永井) would be dragged onto the stage, so "I must go cheer them on!" I went with Sakuma-san (佐久間) who handled *Mononoke* colour direction. It's rare for colour design or colour direction to appear at such events. Hence the "cheering" (laughs).

Work delayed my leaving the studio, arriving at the venue around 8 PM. The venue was packed to capacity with great success, and on stage were host Oguro-san (小黒) and Director Nakamura plus main staff in a row! Nagai-san was properly on the far right.

At the event, Director Nakamura talked and talked (explosion). This person has always been excellent at speaking (laughs). Today too, he got things going with exquisite talk (laughs).

Still, the *Mononoke* staff had really good teamwork. The confidence and dignity of staff who survived hell and left good work - each staff member's talk was filled with depth and confidence, making it a very good event.

Now, let's work hard on *Hakaba* too! (laughs)

Well then.

Continuing the *Saint Seiya* story.

"We're doing *Saint Seiya. Hades Twelve Temples Arc* is decided," said a production department bigwig. "What? No way!" I said. Those were my immediate words.

Early summer 2002. There had been vague rumours since the previous year, but I never imagined it would actually happen. In a sense, *Saint Seiya* at this point seemed late.

While saying that, my mood was incredibly excited, and I loudly declared "I'll do it! I want to do it! Let me absolutely do it!" while wildly waving my hands to appeal for participation (laughs).

Honestly, I was initially somewhat hesitant. Though called a sequel, 15 years had passed since it ended. Too much time had passed. Who would direct? Would Araki-san (荒木) draw? If that era's spirit was missing, even with the *Saint Seiya* package, wouldn't it become something completely different? Such anxieties made me initially think about observing quietly. That's how important *Saint Seiya* was to me.

But such anxieties were easily resolved. Araki-san would draw, Yamauchi-san (山内) would be Chief Director. Other staff from that era were gathering one after another too. The cast would also continue with the longtime members. "It's here!" I absolutely had to participate! (laughs)

For me, this was revenge for that theatrical *Legend of Crimson Youth*. That feeling was also fact.

New wind also came. "I watched the TV broadcast and imitated it playing!" were the words of Director Yamauchi's beloved disciple, Director Nagamine-kun (長峯). Ah, 15 years - I found myself staring into the distance (bitter laugh). For art, Iijima-san (飯島) from Studio MAO joined. And most new of all, Kawase-san's (川瀬) Toei Animation CG department team participated.

15 years from the film & cel painting era, now colouring through photography is the digital processing era. This time's *Saint Seiya* would build most Twelve Temple backgrounds as CG backgrounds. By building CG models of the Twelve Temples and cutting them out according to scenes, we could use not just normal screens but also 3D-style camerawork previously impossible. Additionally, we thought the numerous techniques unleashed by Saints could be shown more three-dimensionally using CG.

So Araki-san's drawn settings finally came up. This time's enemies are Underworld Spectres (冥闘士/サープリス) and Gold Saints revived wearing Surplices (冥衣). First we had to consider their colours. This time without toy manufacturer sponsor constraints, "first try thinking freely," said the director. So referencing original colours while basically aiming for *Saint Seiya* animation-style volume with black-grey-purple combinations.

We had to distinguish between Surplices worn by revived Gold Saints and Surplices of original Spectres like Rhadamanthys (ラダマンティス) through colour differences, while creating unity for overall Surplices and Spectres. So as a common element, I set one "must-use colour" in colour divisions to build colours, plus added slightly pale green to Spectres' white eyes to differentiate from living Saints like Seiya.

Then Kurumada-sensei's (車田) check. Since it differed somewhat from the original, I was secretly nervous, but got OK without particular complaints. Now main story could start.

Actually, when I first placed colours on characters, I deliberately lowered saturation significantly, making them quite subdued. I explored somewhat adult, so-called "un-Toei-like" colour tone development. But it was different. It became "something Saint Seiya-ish" and somehow felt "fake" (bitter laugh). Plus this time, everything was at night. When I placed the initially created subdued versions against backgrounds, they beautifully assimilated with backgrounds (laughs). Ah, this won't work.

So I decided to deliberately create colour tones "Toei-like" or *Saint Seiya*-like for basic colours.

Well, just between us, looking back now, minor Spectres could have had more subdued colour tones (bitter laugh). That's what I think now, but back then I worried and decided quite a lot even then. That was the best at that time, if not better. So I think that was fine.

Instead, we did quite detailed "colour changing" in the main story. From set "normal" colour tones, we created "night colours" by slightly lowering brightness and saturation while adding blue tones - this became the basic colouring for the entire work. When emitting auras or unleashing techniques like "Pegasus Meteor Fist (ペガサス流星拳)," we used "aura colours" with strengthened normal shadow parts. Then we stacked countless "special colourings" for each episode and scene.

Making each episode became educational every time. Skills gradually improved toward later episodes, and things I wanted to try increased. Consulting and trying these with each episode's directors. Like the initial TV series days, I couldn't help enjoying thinking about various things (laughs).

Saints' unleashed techniques mostly became CG effect-added processing. Creating screens through collaboration with the CG section. Though I'd worked on various productions, this was my first experience creating screens through such extensive back-and-forth collaboration. This was also very educational. I got to voice many opinions about CG, and we researched and created screens together.

However, what was difficult was fusing 3D into 2D cel + background screens. *Saint Seiya* is thoroughly 2D animation drawing world. 2D-drawn dimensionality and pure 3D dimensionality screens were often incompatible. Still, gradually understanding the key points episode by episode, direction and animation gradually improved at using and showing CG effects. Well, first it's how much acting can be worked into storyboards.

Then how animators draw that up, and how directors control it further. That remains the foundation.

Among effects we worked on this way, one thing just wouldn't work well: "Pegasus Meteor Fist." The dynamic power accelerating from background to foreground inevitably became weak with CG alone. Despite multiple retakes and attempts, it still failed. So "Pegasus Meteor Fist" became traditional animation, TP + brush.

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